Carnatic Music Theory and History: Study Notes

Subject: Sangeeta Pitamaha Purandara Dasa, Sapta Swaras, Melakarta Ragas, and Talas

Chapter 1: The Father of Carnatic Music — Purandara Dasa

Purandara Dasa (c. 1484 – 1564 CE):
In the history of Indian classical music, **Purandara Dasa** is universally revered and acclaimed as the **Sangeeta Pitamaha** (the **Father of Carnatic Music**). He was a saint-composer of the Haridasa tradition in Karnataka who systematized the entire foundation and pedagogy of South Indian classical music.

Foundational Pedagogical Contributions of Purandara Dasa:
1. **The Graded Pedagogical Syllabus:** Purandara Dasa designed the standard graded exercises that every student of Carnatic music learns to this day: *Sarali Varisais* (stepwise exercises), *Janta Varisais* (twinning exercises), *Dhatu Varisais* (zigzag patterns), *Alankaras* (tala exercises), and *Geethams* (simple melodic compositions).
2. **Selection of Mayamalavagowla:** He designated **Mayamalavagowla** (the 15th Melakarta ragam) as the foundational raga for beginners. He chose Mayamalavagowla because of its symmetrical structure: both poorvanga (S-R1-G3-M1) and uttaranga (P-D1-N3-S') feature identical semitone intervals between Sa-Ri and Pa-Dha, making it ideal for vocal stability and ear training.
3. **Codification of the Suladi Sapta Talas:** He formulated the system of seven fundamental rhythmic cycles: Dhruva, Matya, Rupaka, Jhampa, Triputa, Ata, and Eka talas.
4. **Prolific Compositions:** He composed tens of thousands of devotional songs, Kritis, and Suladis (Devaranamas) embedding profound philosophical truths in simple musical expressions.

Chapter 2: Core Theoretical Framework of Carnatic Music

1. Nada, Sruti, and Swaras:

• **Nada:** Musical sound, originating as subtle inner vibration (Anahata) and realized as audible sound (Ahata).

• **Sruti:** The microtonal pitch interval. Carnatic music recognizes 22 distinct srutis within an octave.

• **The Sapta Swaras:** The seven basic musical notes:

1. **Shadjam (Sa)** — Fundamental tonic (invariant, Achala swara).
2. **Rishabham (Ri)** — Suddha Ri (R1), Chatusruti Ri (R2), Shatsruti Ri (R3).
3. **Gandharam (Ga)** — Suddha Ga (G1), Sadharana Ga (G2), Antara Ga (G3).
4. **Madhyamam (Ma)** — Suddha Ma (M1), Prati Ma (M2).
5. **Panchamam (Pa)** — Fifth degree (invariant, Achala swara).
6. **Dhaivatam (Dha)** — Suddha Dha (D1), Chatusruti Dha (D2), Shatsruti Dha (D3).
7. **Nishadam (Ni)** — Suddha Ni (N1), Kaisiki Ni (N2), Kakali Ni (N3).

Together with Sa and Pa, these generate the 16 Swarasthanas.

2. The Melakarta Raga Scheme:

Codified by Venkatamakhin in his treatise *Chaturdandi Prakasika* (17th century), the system comprises **72 Melakarta** (parent heptatonic) ragas. They are systematically grouped into 12 Chakras of 6 ragas each. Ragas 1–36 use Suddha Madhyamam (M1); ragas 37–72 use Prati Madhyamam (M2). Derived scales are known as *Janya ragas*.

Chapter 3: Tala System and The Carnatic Trinity

The Tala System:

Tala governs meter in Carnatic music. A tala consists of Angas (limbs):

• **Laghu (I):** A beat followed by finger counts. Can have 5 Jathis: Tisra (3), Chaturasra (4), Khanda (5), Misra (7), Sankeerna (9).

• **Dhrutam (O):** A beat followed by a wave of the hand (2 aksharas).

• **Anudhrutam (U):** A single beat (1 akshara).

Applying the 5 jathis to the 7 Suladi Sapta Talas produces the 35 Tala scheme. The most popular tala in concerts is **Adi Tala** (Chaturasra Jathi Triputa Tala: I4 O O = 8 aksharas).

The Trinity of Carnatic Music (18th–19th Century):

• **Tyagaraja (1767–1847):** Master of devotional Kritis, Pancharatna Kritis, and expressive sangathis in Telugu.

• **Muthuswami Dikshitar (1775–1835):** Known for grand Sanskrit Kritis set in intellectual vilamba laya, Kamalamba Navavarna Kritis, and rich gamakas.

• **Syama Sastri (1762–1827):** Renowned for intricate rhythmic patterns, Swarajatis, and soulful compositions dedicated to Goddess Kamakshi.